Data Center News

Think Tank Pennsylvania

Tuesday, October 20, 2026

Emergency order put data centers on their own backup generators

Energy Secretary Chris Wright signed emergency order 202-26-50 on October 12; it ran October 13 through 16. The order let PJM — the grid operator for Pennsylvania and 12 other states — call on extra power plants as a fall heat wave struck during planned maintenance shutdowns. About 62,000 megawatts of generation sat unavailable. Before resorting to rolling blackouts, PJM could order data centers and other large customers to run their own backup generators. No homes lost power. PJM says such mild-weather emergencies are becoming the new normal as data-center demand grows faster than new supply.

https://www.delawareonline.com/story/news/2026/10/13/power-grid-emergency-in-pennsylvania-what-residents-need-to-know-now/92235540007/ (Delaware Online / USA Today Network)

Hazle Township said no to $10,000 per household for an AWS data center

Hazle Township residents in Luzerne County are pushing back against “Project Hazelnut,” a 15-building campus tied to Amazon Web Services. Developer NorthPoint Development offered a $165 million community-benefits package, including a $10,000 grant to each of roughly 4,500 eligible households once the first building opens around late 2027. Many residents read the money as a bribe. They worry about falling property values and strain on electricity, water, and roads. The township rejected the project on zoning grounds in June and imposed a 180-day pause, which NorthPoint is challenging in court. Amazon says it has no final agreement with NorthPoint.

https://cybernews.com/ai-news/pennsylvania-direct-cash-data-center/ (Cybernews)

PUC study names 21 retired power plants that could come back to life

The Pennsylvania Public Utility Commission (PUC) is hunting for retired power plants that could return to service. A $2 million grant from the U.S. Department of Energy funds the Pennsylvania Accelerated Transmission and Energy Redevelopment Study — PATER for short. Researchers screened 76 retired sites and narrowed the list to 21, targeting five to seven prime sites for new generation by March. Two Western Pennsylvania sites made the list: the coal-fired Armstrong Generating Station in Armstrong County and Cambria Cogeneration in Cambria County. The study warns the region could face rolling blackouts even with new generation built as data centers come online.

https://www.wesanews.org/environment-energy/2026-10-19/study-retired-power-plants-reactivate (90.5 WESA)

Springdale data center faces county scrutiny; residents get another say Oct 28

Allegheny County’s own review of the proposed Dynamo data center in Springdale found 97 problems with the developer’s plans. The site is the former Cheswick coal plant; the project could draw as much power as about 200,000 homes. At an October 14 virtual hearing, dozens of residents urged the county to deny the plan, citing noise, air pollution, property values, and rising utility bills. The county found no proof the arsenic-contaminated site has been fully cleaned up. An in-person hearing follows October 28 at the Springdale borough building; written comments stay open through November 30, and the county’s decision is due January 26.

https://www.wesanews.org/environment-energy/2026-10-15/allegheny-county-springdale-data-center-noise-pollution (90.5 WESA)

MARK YOUR CALENDAR — WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 28

Allegheny County holds an in-person hearing October 28 at the Springdale borough building, where the developer will show revised plans. Written comments stay open through November 30.



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